

Note: The issues of finite and non-finite verb is the major factor that distinguishes the phrase from the clause. Therefore, for an expression that has a verb to be identified as a phrase, you must establish the following:

- a. If the verb in the expression given is preceded by 'to', it means the verb is non-finite. Therefore, the expression is a phrase. Example To pass the examination involves hard work.
- b. If the verb in the expression given is in the – ing form, the verb is non-finite, hence the expression is a phrase. Example Giving to the poor attracts God's blessing
- c. If the verb in the expression given is made to function as an adjective, it is a non-finite verb and the expression is a phrase e.g. He told me to replace the broken bottle.

Note: broken is a verb (past participle of break), but in the sentence above, it is qualifying the noun "bottle" which is the function of an adjective.

Types of Phrase – Noun Phrase

There are three types of phrase namely: Noun phrase, adjectival phrase and adverbial phrase.

- A. Noun Phrase: In a noun phrase, the head word must be a noun or pronoun. A noun phrase can be replaced by a pronoun Examples
 - i. I saw the village head master
 - ii. The man at the gate is my father
 - iii. The old woman sleeping in the room has just been discouraged from the hospital.
 - iv. Sola told me to replace the broken bottle
 - v. I gave the money to the most brilliant student in the class.
 - vi. To sleep without light is frightening

Functions of Noun Phrase

Like noun, noun phrase has six different grammatical functions

1. Subject of Verb: When the noun phrase occupies the first position in the sentence, it functions as the subject of the verb that follows it. Examples
 - i. Sleeping without light is not something I enjoy.

Function: Subject of the verb "is"